

ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A kingdom cursed by the death-throes of a dreaming god

BACKGROUND

The players are drawn to the Hollow Dominion by a shared dream — a vision of a dying god calling for help. Upon arrival, they discover the kingdom is cursed by the death-throes of **Mordath, the Dreaming God**. The landscape warps unpredictably, nightmare creatures stalk the roads, and the populace is divided between those fighting to survive and those who've given in to madness.

The players discover they are **Dreambound** — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness, marked by a glowing sigil. They cannot leave until the curse is broken — and if Mordath dies without resolution, they die with him.

ADVENTURE DETAILS

System*D&D 5e*

Levels*1–3*

Sessions*3–4*

Players*3–5*

Tone*Dark fantasy mystery*

FACTIONS

Waking Guard*Soldiers maintaining order*

Dreamseekers*Cultists seeking freedom*

Veil Court*Surviving nobility*

The Unbound*Nightmare-consumed victims*

ADVENTURE HOOK: THE SHARED DREAM

"For three nights running, you've had the same dream. A vast chamber of white stone, a figure on a throne robed in starlight, its face hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain. It speaks: 'Come. Please. Before it is too late.' On the fourth day, you each find a mark on your skin — a glowing sigil shaped like an eye within a crescent moon."

PART 1: THE ASHEN GATE

The entrance to the Hollow Dominion — and the point of no return

DANGER

ARRIVAL

"The archway rises from the mist like a broken tooth. Once-grand stone, now cracked and leaking purple dream-energy that makes your sigil burn warm. Beyond the gate, trees grow sideways and the road shifts when you're not looking."

ENCOUNTER: ELDON VOSS, THE GATEKEEPER

An old man in a tattered guard's uniform. Half-mad but sharp. "You're Dreambound. Welcome to the nightmare, friends. Mind the roads after dark. Things come through from the Dreaming Depths when the sun goes down."

The Dominion has been cursed for **six months**

The landscape warps unpredictably

Nightmare creatures emerge at dusk

The **Waking Guard** maintain order; the **Dreamseekers** want Mordath dead

"**Don't sleep near running water** — that's where the nightmares come through strongest."

DM NOTE

Eldon was once a respected captain. The curse broke his mind but fragments of wisdom remain. Treat him with kindness and he's a valuable source of information.

THE TWISTED MARCH

Three days through nightmare-ravaged countryside

RANDOM EVENTS (ROLL D6 EACH DAY)

- 1 — **Shifting Path:** DC 12 Survival or lose 1d4 hours backtracking.
- 2 — **Dream Echo:** Ghostly vision of the Dominion before the curse. One player sees Mordath before he began dying.
- 3 — **Nightmare Spawn:** A **Nightmare Wolf** attacks (Wolf stat block: HP 15, Bite +4, 2d4+2 piercing + 1d4 psychic, immune to charm).
- 4 — **Traveler:** Refugee warns Dreamseekers are "harvesting" Dreambound in eastern villages.
- 5 — **Dream Shimmer:** One player phases into Mordath's dream — sees a white throne room, hears "Find the three keys."
- 6 — **Peaceful Night:** Waking Guard outpost. Rest safely and get information.

"The land remembers what it was. Sometimes, at the edges of your vision, you can see it — green fields, blue sky, children playing. Then you blink, and it's all twisted again."

MAP: THE TWISTED MARCH

Regional map — Ashen Gate to Drearym



The Twisted March — Three days' travel through nightmare-ravaged forest. Purple pools mark thin points where dream-energy leaks into the waking world.

MAP KEY

Ashen Gate (South): Entry point. Meet Eldon Voss.

Waking Guard Outpost: Safe haven with supplies and information.

The Wellspring: Ancient well leaking purple energy. Side quest: rescue Lissa Greel.

Ruined Shrine: Old monastery with lore about Mordath.

Purple Pools: Thin points between worlds. Nightmare creatures emerge after dark.

Drearym (North): First major town. Faction tensions.

PART 2: THE TOWN OF DREARYM

A town on the edge of collapse

DANGER

ARRIVAL

"Drearym was once a prosperous market town of 2,000. Now it holds perhaps 800. A makeshift wall of sharpened logs surrounds the town. Purple mist hovers in the alleys. Some buildings lean at impossible angles. People eye your Dreambound marks with pity and suspicion."

KEY LOCATIONS

- 1. The Vigorous Dog (Inn)** — Run by **Marta Greel**, a former adventurer who lost her leg to a nightmare creature. Key information source. Her daughter **Lissa** (16) went missing near the Wellspring. 50gp reward for her return.
- 2. Waking Guard Barracks** — **Captain Rena Ashford**, stern but fair. Asks the party to investigate nightmare sightings on the eastern road (30gp reward). Warns about Brother Caelum.
- 3. The Wellspring** — Ancient well outside town, leaking purple dream-energy. Lissa disappeared here.

BROTHER CAELUM — DREAMSEEKER PRIEST

Charismatic priest (CHA 18) preaching that Mordath's death will "free" the Dreambound. **Belief:** Killing the god ends the curse. **Reality:** It would also kill every Dreambound, including the players. **Secret:** He's being manipulated by something in Mordath's dreams that wants the god dead.

MAP: DREARYM

Town map — Key locations and faction territories



Drearym — A walled market town under siege. Purple water flows through the settlement, corrupting the land.

KEY LOCATIONS

- A — **The Vigorous Dog:** Marta Greel's inn. Safe haven.
- B — **Waking Guard Barracks:** Captain Ashford's headquarters.
- C — **Old Town Chapel:** Brother Caelum's Dreamseeker meeting place.
- D — **Market Square:** Central gathering place for refugees.
- E — **The Wellspring:** Outside the walls. Lissa Greel was last seen here.

ENCOUNTER: THE DREAMING WELL

A thin point between worlds

⚠ DANGER ⚠

SETUP

The well is a thin point between the waking world and Mordath's dreams. **Lissa Greel** is trapped in a Dream Loop — reliving her favorite memory on repeat. 2 **Nightmare Spawn** (Shadow stat block: purple-tinged, psychic damage, Dream Vulnerability: 1d6 radiant from moonlight).

RESCUING LISSA

Option 1 — Physical Pull: DC 14 Strength check to grab Lissa's body. Nightmare Spawn attack to prevent this.

Option 2 — Enter the Dream: Touch water, fail DC 13 WIS save. Inside: sunlit field, Lissa playing. DC 13 Persuasion to convince her to leave.

Success: Marta becomes a valuable ally. **Failure:** Marta blames the Dreamseekers.

DM NOTE
If a player enters the dream, they glimpse Mordath's white throne room and the three keys. Foreshadow Book 2

PART 3: THE GATEHOUSE OF DREAMS

The boundary between worlds

DANGER

THE GATEHOUSE

A fortress built into a cliff — the boundary between the waking world and Mordath's consciousness. Once a monastery, now a ruin consumed by dream-energy. Four wings: Dormitory, Library, Chapel, Gate Hall.

KEY ENCOUNTERS

The Library: Lore about Mordath — god of dreams who foresaw his own death. His curse is not malicious, just a divine fever dream.

The Chapel: Veil is thinnest here. 3 Nightmare Spawn emerge from walls. DC 13 WIS save or pulled into brief dream vision of Mordath pleading.

The Gate Hall (Climax): The Dreaming Gate — a massive portal of swirling purple energy. Through it: Mordath's white throne room and the dying god himself.

BOSS: THE NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

Guardian of the Dreaming Gate

DANGER

THE GUARDIAN

"The figure in purple armor stands before the gate, twin blades of crackling pink energy humming in its hands. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow — a weight that presses against your chest like deep water."

Can be fought (hard for level 3) or reasoned with (DC 15 Persuasion — it's a Dreambound soul guarding the gate out of duty). If reasoned with, it steps aside.

NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

AC15

HP85

STR18 (+4)

DEX14 (+2)

CON18 (+4)

ABILITIES

Energy Blades+7, 2d8+4 + 1d4 *psychic*

Life Drain+7, 3d6+4 *psychic, heals half*

Dream StepTeleport 30ft (*bonus*)

ResistanceNon-magical weapons

TOUCHING THE GATE

Vision: Mordath on his throne, dying. Voice: "Three keys. Find them. Before the hollow ones consume everything." Flash of three locations. Player gains **Dreamsense** — detect dream-energy within 30ft.

END OF BOOK 1

Return to Drearym — and a cliffhanger for Book 2

RESOLUTION

Mordath is dying — not trying to harm anyone

There are **three keys** that can resolve the curse

Someone wants Mordath dead enough to manipulate people

The players are Dreambound — tied to Mordath's fate

CLIFFHANGER FOR BOOK 2

"As you leave the Gatehouse, you see them. A vast army of Unbound — hundreds strong — marching toward Drearym. At their head: Brother Caelum. His 'sharing circle' was a trap. He's been converting Dreambound into Unbound, building an army to storm the Fractured Court and kill Mordath by force."

TREASURE & REWARDS

Guardian's Longsword: +1 longsword, glows purple, +1d4 psychic vs. undead/fiends

Marta's Gratitude: Potion of Greater Healing + Cloak of Elvenkind (if Lissa saved)

Monastery Library: Book on Mordath (25gp or useful for Book 2)

Milestone: Party reaches level 3 by end of this adventure.

GM NOTES

Tone: This adventure should feel like waking up in someone else's nightmare. The horror is wrongness — familiar things made strange.

Moral Complexity: Neither the Waking Guard nor the Dreamseekers are wrong. Both goals conflict with the players' survival.

Connections to Book 2: Plant seeds throughout — references to the Fractured Court, Queen Thessaly, the Architect, and the three keys.

